

Web watch

Read about the latest interesting news related to the web – from updates to added features and more

Security watch

Check out the latest developments in security from the attacks on Indian websites to the Android Wear encryption bug

The end of Nokia X

...and the beginning of everything else new this past month

Microsoft loses 18,000

Microsoft announced that it would be cutting 18,000 jobs in the next year in what's believed to be its biggest round of layoffs as a part of ongoing restructuring efforts. The company also announced that it would be scrapping Nokia's X Android smartphones in favor of Windows Phone.

Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella stated that Nokia's Devices and Services business, which it acquired for \$5 billion last year, will be most affected. Microsoft plans to cut 12,500 "professional and factory positions" by the end of the year. In an email to employees, Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella explains that the company's new strategy is designed to make it "more agile" moving forward, allowing teams to work more freely.

Microsoft Devices chief, Stephen Elop details the company's renewed focus on Windows Phone: "In addition to the portfolio already planned, we plan to deliver additional lower-cost Lumia devices by shifting select future Nokia X designs and products to Windows Phone devices. We expect to make this shift immediately while continuing to sell and support existing Nokia X products."

Nokia launched the X Android series of smartphones earlier this year, creating much excitement but the phone lacked good hardware for the price category it was placed in. Microsoft announced its successor, the X2 just last month.



Nokia's now-doomed entry into the Android market

Microsoft is also reportedly planning to scrap Nokia's feature phones, including the Nokia Asha series and Series 40. The devices will shift to what is described as "maintenance mode," and services to support existing devices will be shut down over the next 18 months. "This means there will be no new features or updates to services on any mobile phone's platform as a result of these plans," said Jo Harlow, head of the phone business under

Microsoft Devices. Microsoft is also planning to offer Nokia MixRadio as a third-party service to iOS and Android. Until it's sold, it has been moved into maintenance mode.

Free Internet on DataWind

DataWind's budget tablets will now come bundled with 12 months of free unlimited Internet browsing with BSNL in southern India. The tablet maker has also entered into a partnership with retailer, UniverCell, to market the company's UbiSlate tablets. Until recently, DataWind products were primarily sold via e-commerce and direct-to-consumer channels such as TV home-shopping.

DataWind, known for its Aakash tablets, will be offering its UbiSlate series of models including 7Cx, 7C Plus, 7CZ and 3G7 which are priced between ₹3,999 and ₹4,999 with the free Internet access. DataWind's entire product range of UbiSlate Tablet PCs and PocketSurfer smartphones will be available at more than 500 of UniverCell's retail outlets spread

across southern India. Suneet Singh Tuli, chief executive at DataWind sees UniverCell as a significant player in the retail market. Speaking about the association with BSNL for its bundled internet service, he said, "This unique partnership validates our technology and belief in low cost internet connectivity sans barriers."

The company will focus on rural areas to increase its market share. "We ship around 2,500-3,000 devices a day now, and in the first quarter of the year, we were the largest supplier of tablets in India. We sold a million units in the last one year (15 months) plus 1 lakh units (of Aakash) to the Government," said Tuli.

Tuli added that DataWind would also participate in bidding for the 22-lakh 'Aakash-4' project expected to happen in mid-December. The tablet maker also has plans to enter overseas markets such as the UK, the US and Canada. DataWind already has presence in 13 countries including Mexico, Nepal, Bangladesh, Zambia, Tanzania, Uruguay and Sri Lanka.

"We are aiming to add around two countries every month over the next few months," Tuli added.

Firefox OS in Asia soon

Open Source giant Mozilla last month announced its expansion plans on its blog. This means that phones from ZTE, LG and others currently running the Firefox OS may soon be available in Europe, Latin America



Free Internet browsing in south India